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THE AUTONOMOUS COMMERCE PLAYBOOK

A CXO's Guide To AI-Native Execution In 2026

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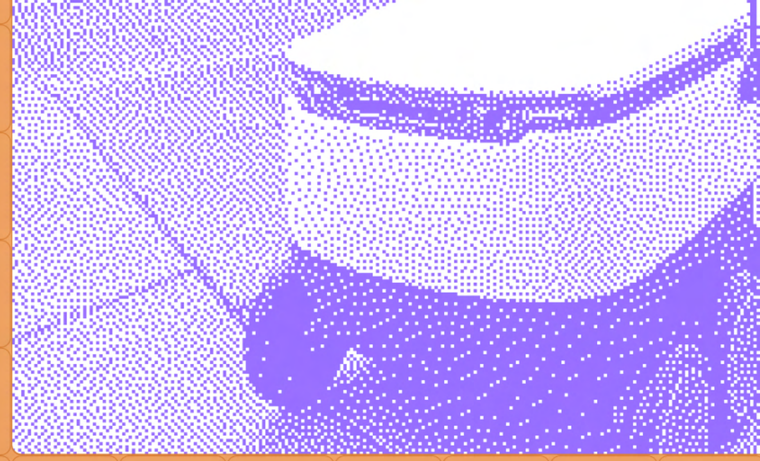

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01 THE STATE OF COMMERCE 2025

Signals, shocks & shifts

Understand how the commerce landscape materially shifted in 2025.

These shocks, signals and shifts define the operating environment you will be responding to in 2026

Shocks

Where 2025 broke the recent patterns & hit harder than expected

SHOCK 1

ASPs dipped as value-first buying took over

After a few years of elevated festive and discretionary spending, 2025 clearly swung toward value-first behaviour: people still bought, but at lower price points, smaller baskets, waiting for deals and trading down instead of paying full price.

90%

of fashion consumers say they will wait for discounts or trade down rather than pay full price when prices rise

- McKinsey's An update on US consumer sentiment, 2025

5.3%

drop in holiday spending in 2025 from 2024, the steepest drop in 5 years

- PwC survey

< ₹1,000

ASP for majority of orders on key marketplaces like Amazon and Myntra during the biggest Indian festive season, a noticeable shift into lower ASP buckets compared to earlier periods

- Fynd's Festive Season Report for Fashion 2025

SHOCK 2

Gen Z spent lower

Gen Z's actual spend in 2025 is lower than earlier expectations and involves planned cutbacks. These trends reflect a broader value-driven, cautious approach rather than the strong spending surge many retailers once expected.

23%

expected cut in Gen Z's holiday spending, despite their long-term spending power.

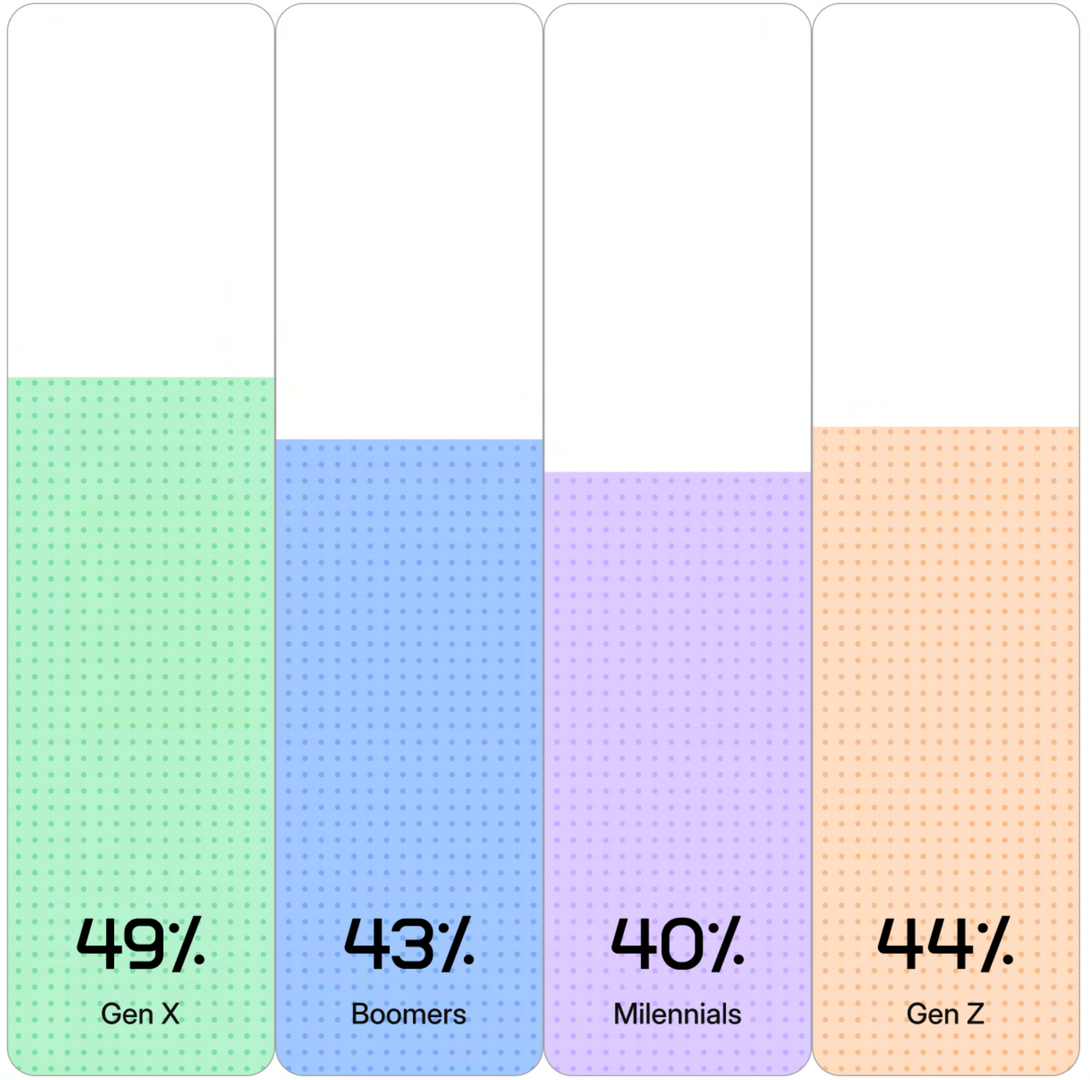
-PwCs Holiday Outlook 2025

This contradicts older expectations that Gen Z would be the main holiday growth engine and forces retailers to rethink youth-focused strategies.

People engage in value-seeking behaviors, challenging a notion that financial pressures contribute to younger generations

Value seekers span all ages and incomes. While Millennials and Gen Z may be more financially strapped, nearly half of Baby Boomers and Gen X are also value seekers.

- Deloitte's Consumers Shift Spending to Brands That Offer More Value for the Price, 2025



Shifts

Structural changes in behaviour and models

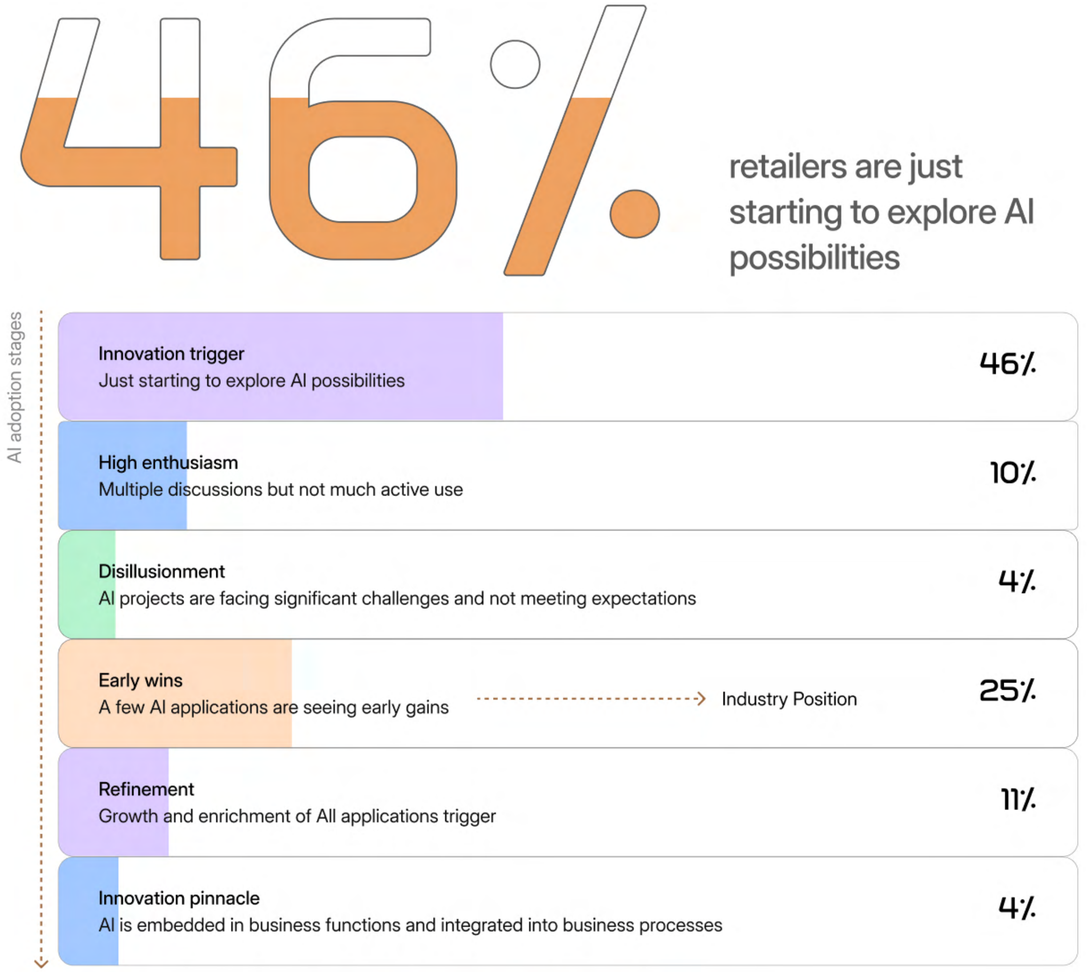
SHIFT 1

AI shifted from “experiment” to “board priority”, but maturity stayed low and uneven

2025 is the year AI stopped being a side show, it entered almost every planning and strategy conversation. Yet, when you look under the hood, most retailers still describe themselves as early-stage, with only a few mature, scaled deployments.

The AI in Retail 2025 report shows that nearly half are still "just starting to explore" with early wins only, and very few have embedded AI across functions.

What stalled most organizations was not access to AI, but the absence of systems designed to let AI decide and act autonomously.



Source: AI in Retail Report, 2025

AI is shifting from isolated deployments to cornerstone of enterprise-wide transformation

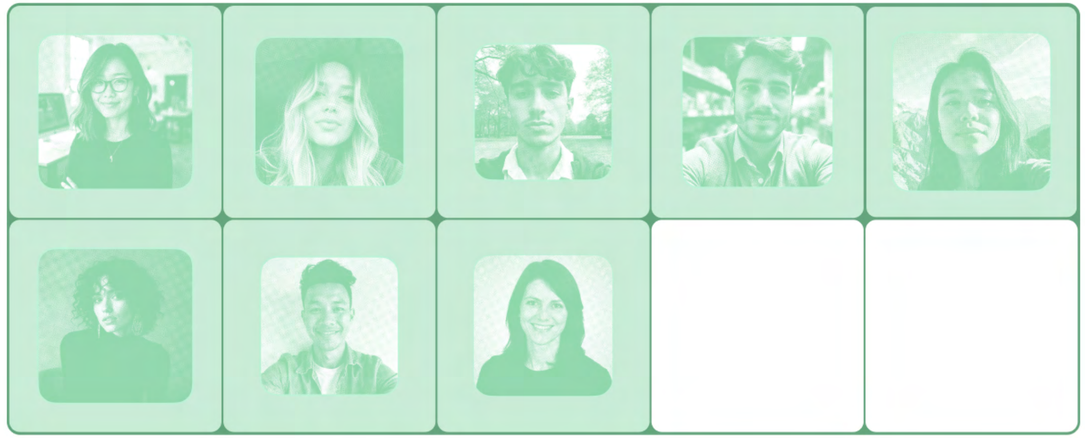
- PwC's 2025 Consumer Markets Work

SHIFT 2

Loyalty shifting to rewards + value, not just brand love

8 out of 10 consumers say earning and redeeming financial rewards is the most important attribute of a loyalty programme, signalling a move from purely emotional loyalty to value-anchored loyalty.

- Deloitte's research



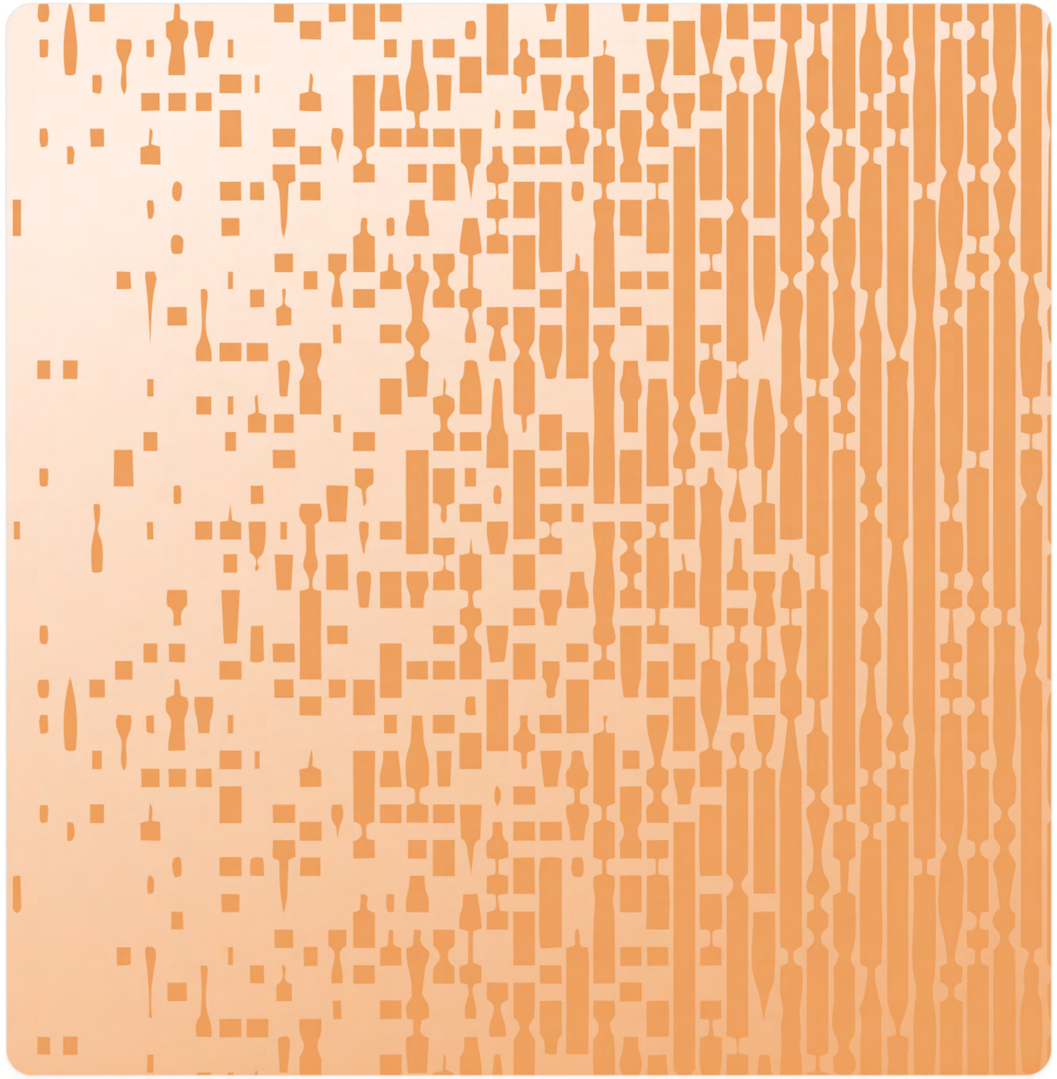
Many existing loyalty schemes show "disengagement", pushing retailers to redesign programmes around immediate, visible value.

The future of loyalty is emotional. Not transactional.

- Forbes, 2025

Signals

Patterns that became clearer in 2025



SIGNAL 1

Omnichannel and store-based fulfillment as the new normal

The definition of a store changed. For many brands, stores now sell, fulfil and support often in the same day. They act as **showrooms, pickup points, ship-from-store nodes, return centres, and clienteling hubs** that influence online and offline revenue together and not separate P&Ls.

Global shopper surveys show that **over half of shoppers have used some mix of buy online, pick up in store (BOPIS), ship-from-store, or returning online orders in-store**, and many retailers now design store KPIs around both in-store sales and online orders influenced or fulfilled by stores, not just walk-ins.

Orders were shipped from stores for fashion brands during Indian festive season, 2025

These trends align with global trends:

>50% online orders were fulfilled from local Walmart stores

43% of online orders were shipped from store by Best Buys

SIGNAL 2

Data & tech stacks integrations quietly became make-or-break capabilities

By 2025, the limiting factor isn't ideas or tools, it's whether systems talk to each other and whether data is clean enough for AI and unified commerce to work. It isn't "**do we have an AI idea**?" It is "**can our systems and data actually support it**?"

Siloed systems, messy product and customer data, and brittle integrations started blocking progress more than "lack of ideas". Clean, connected data and interoperable systems became the difference between slideware and reality

According to AI in Retail Report 2025,

Top enablers in retail:

- Accurate & consistent data
- Integrated data across systems
- Interoperable tech and scalable data platforms

Major challenges to implementing AI solutions:

- Siloed/disjointed data
- Integration complexity
- Data security
- Uncertain ROI

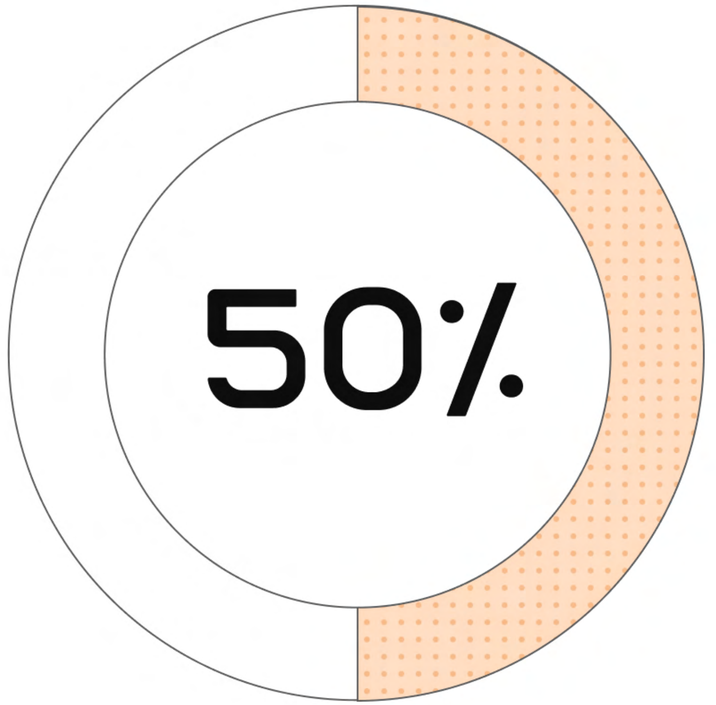
SIGNAL 3

Supply chains stayed volatile under “instant-commerce” speed expectations

More channels + faster promises = more pressure on the backbone

The speed expectation moved faster than the infrastructure. **Same-day, next-day and 30-minute promises (plus flash events and viral trends)** made **demand more spiky, less predictable,** forcing warehouses, dark stores and last-mile networks to operate in a state of constant readiness.

Retailers cite supply chain disruptions and economic uncertainity as there biggest challenges.



- Rizing, 2025 | Retail Technology Trends & Challenges

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02 BOARDROOM BATTLEGROUNDS

7 Questions Shaping 2026

If 2025 was the year that reset commerce, 2026 is the year leadership has to respond with clarity. Each shock or shift leaves you with one hard question in the boardroom.

When shoppers default to discounts and low price bands, where will our profit actually come from?

Are we betting on higher-margin assortments, operational efficiency or dynamic pricing & promotions?

Are we redesigning our commerce stack so we can actually see and optimize contribution margin across channels and journeys?

If Gen Z is spending less, how do we design propositions, experiences and channels that still win their wallet share?

Are we built to test new formats, price points and drops fast enough?

Do we really understand Gen Z engagement data across social, marketplaces, brand.com and stores?

We talk about AI in every meeting, but which commerce decisions are we prepared to hand over to the system?

Where will AI be allowed to execute end-to-end within guardrails, not just recommend or report?

Over the next 2–3 years, how quickly are we reducing human intervention loops in core commerce execution?

If loyalty is now “value + relevance + ease”, not just brand love, what kind of programe and data spine do we need?

Can we recognize and reward a customer meaningfully across marketplaces, brand.com, stores, quick commerce and B2B?

Are we able to personalize journeys in real time or are we still running points programes on fragmented data?

Are our stores just P&L islands, or are they fully integrated nodes in our commerce and fulfillment network?

How should we measure stores: only walk-in sales, or total business influenced (endless aisle, click-and-collect, returns, clienteling)?

Do our metrics, incentives and systems reflect that?

What tech and processes do store teams need to sell, fulfil and service for all channels?

With supply chains volatile under instant-commerce expectations, how do we deliver that speed without destroying margin?

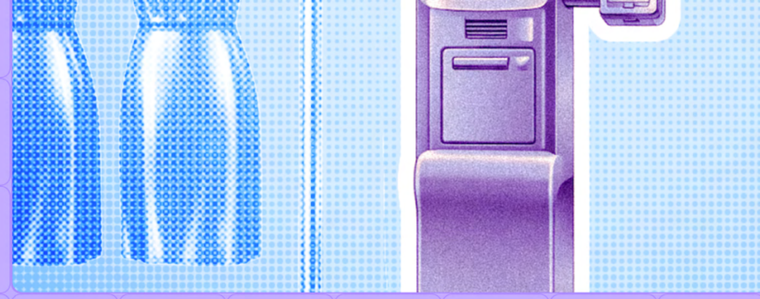
How do we use DCs, dark stores and retail stores together to hit the right SLA at the right cost?

What role should AI-driven OMS, WMS, TMS and managed logistics play in making our promises realistic and profitable?

With fragmented systems and messy data, what is the core platform and data model we are betting on for the next 5–7 years?

Do we converge on one product truth, one order truth, one customer truth, or keep patching integrations?

Are we choosing a unified, AI-native commerce platform, or another layer of point tools?



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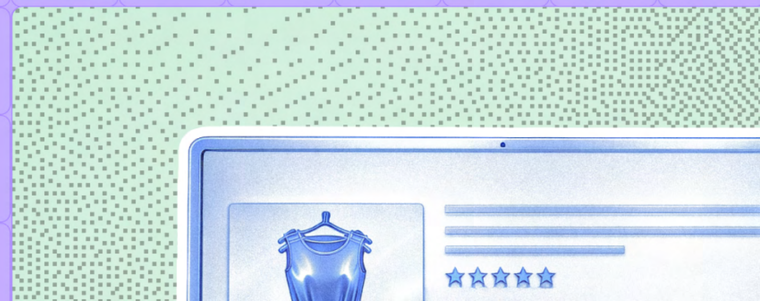
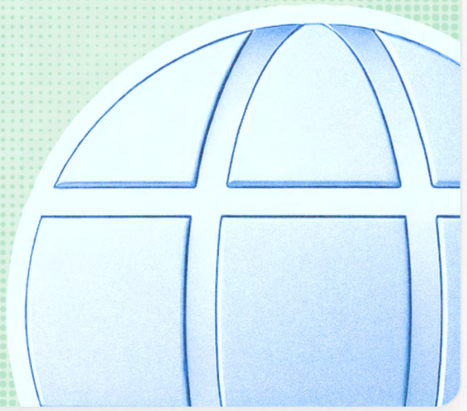
03 HOW LEADERS SHOULD RESPOND IN 2026

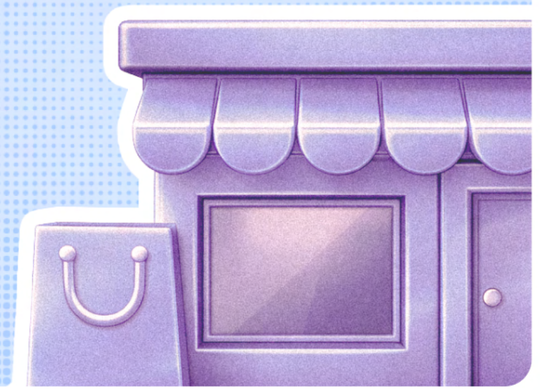


Given this,
what should YOU do as a functional leader in 2026?

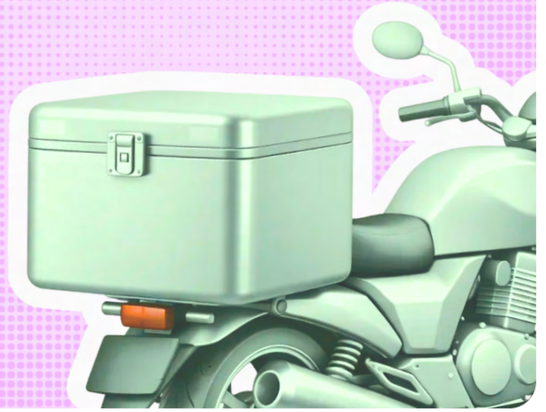
Ecommerce & digital leaders



Retail & store operations leaders



Supply chain, fulfillment
& logistics leaders



Ecommerce & digital leaders

For CDOs, VPs Ecommerce, Heads of Digital/Ecommerce, CMOs

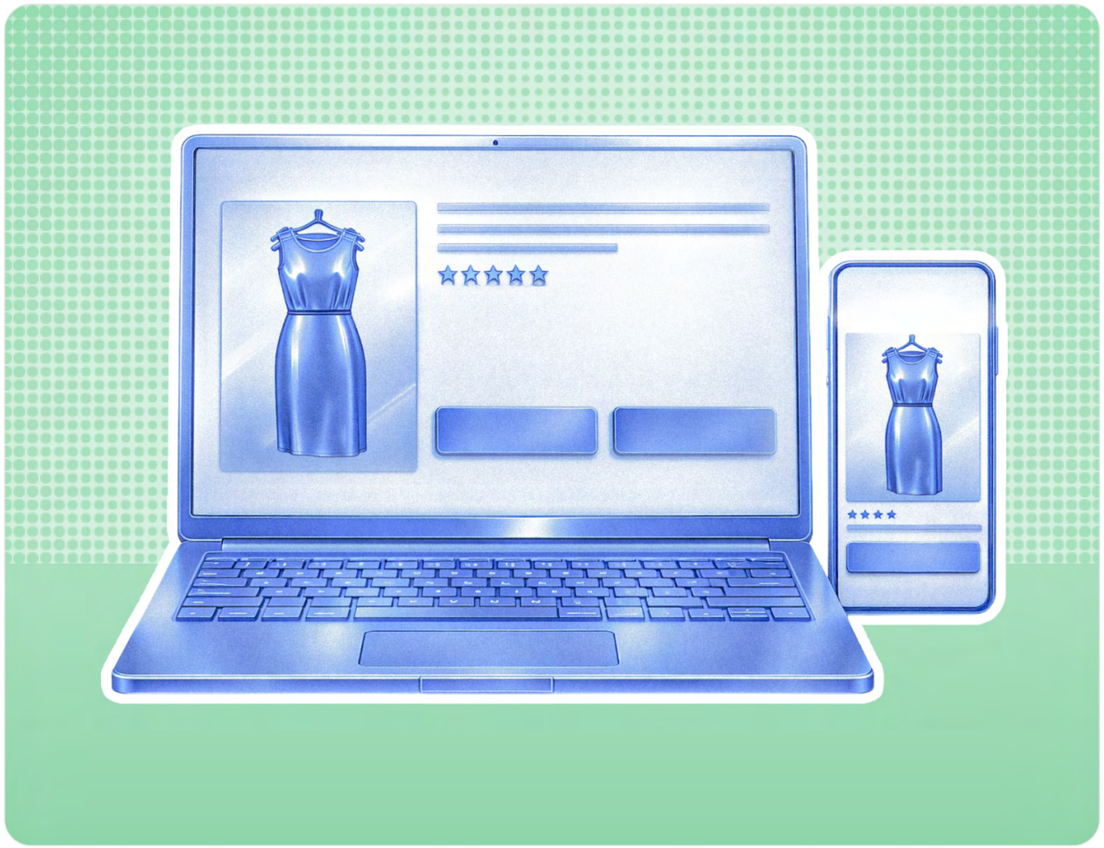
Your mandate in 2026

Turn value-driven, low-ASP demand into profitable digital revenue

Make AI a core part and **move to system-led execution** across the funnel: catalog → discovery → conversion → retention

Eliminate channel-by-channel coordination through **system-level orchestration**

Protect margin in a low-ASP environment by letting systems execute faster than people can

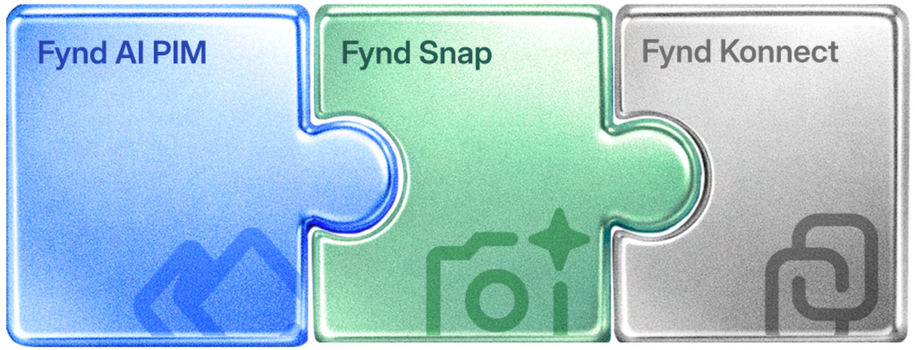


Your 2026 action agenda

Own a single, AI-led product & content truth

If you want profitable growth, you cannot afford messy catalog and slow content

- Consolidate all product data, attributes and media into one AI-led PIM
- Automate enrichment, translations, SEO fields and channel variations
- Move imagery from studio bottlenecks to AI-first production

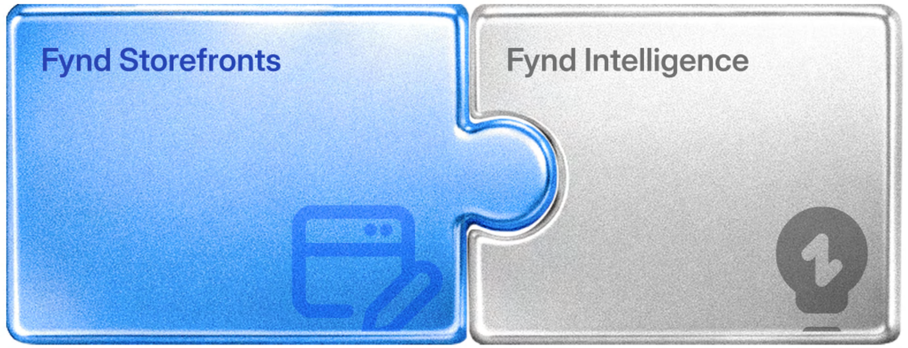


for AI-led cataloging | for on-model AI shoots | for centralized listing

Make storefront execution agentic, not page-led

In a value-obsessed world, your storefront must work as hard as your media

- Standardize on a mobile-first, conversion-optimized storefront
- Give growth and merchandising teams the ability to change layouts, messaging, price displays and bundles without waiting on engineering
- Automate A/B test page structures, offers, nudges, and journeys



for AI-powered DIY branded storefronts | AI agents for customer targeting

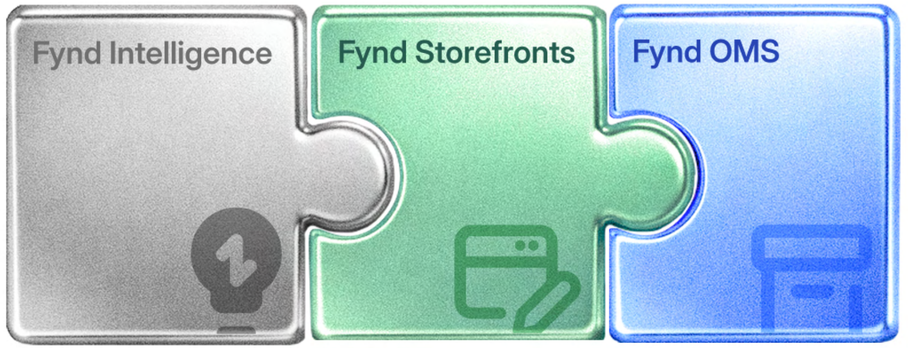
Design value-led offers and loyalty that actually show up

Loyalty now means: "You know me, you save me money or effort, and you don't waste my time."

Use unified data to identify high-value, at-risk and value-sensitive cohorts

Build reward and offer mechanics that are visible and immediate, not abstract points

Personalize bundles, promotions and communications based on profitability + preference, not generic discounts.



AI agents for personalization

to implement dynamic offers on D2C

to apply offers across channels

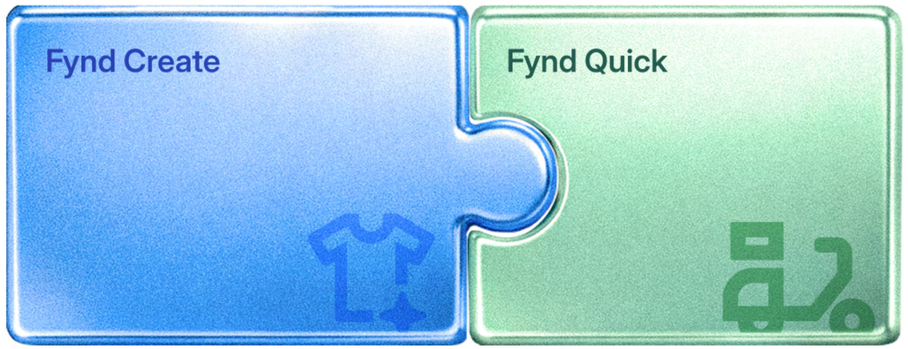
Respond fast to Gen Z behaviour and channel shifts

Gen Z's reduced spend doesn't mean reduced influence

Use data from social, marketplaces, brand.com and stores to spot what's resonating

Launch new formats, collabs, drops, or private labels quickly across channels

Treat marketplaces and quick commerce as signal as well as sales, feeding back into assortment and pricing



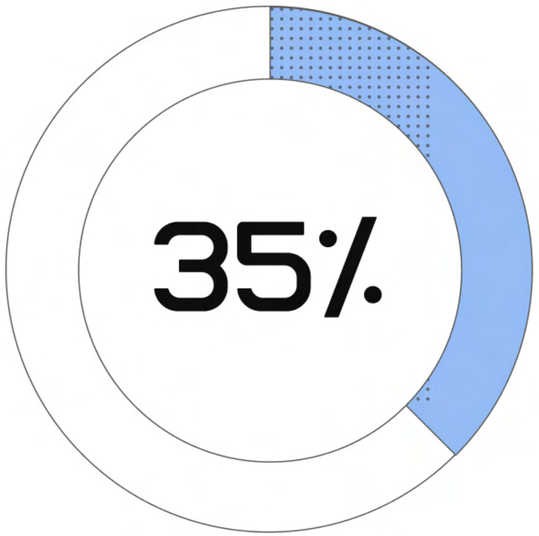
for fast fashion drops aligned with AI-searched trends

for hyperlocal faster deliveries

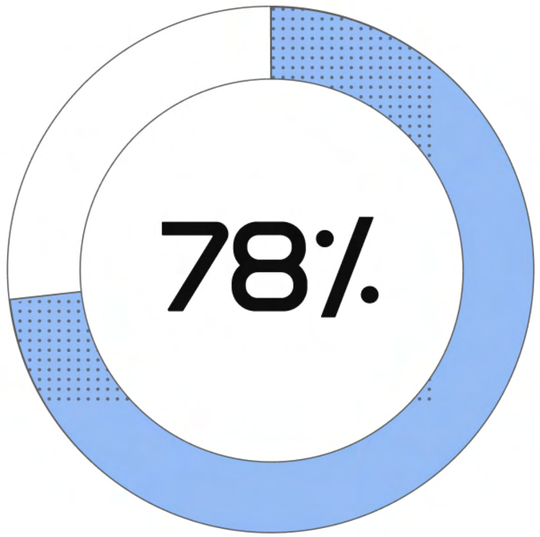
Pro tip for ecommerce & digital leaders

Stop optimizing channels, optimize decision speed. The faster your system can decide what to show, offer, promise, and fulfill per customer, the more margin you protect in a value-led market.

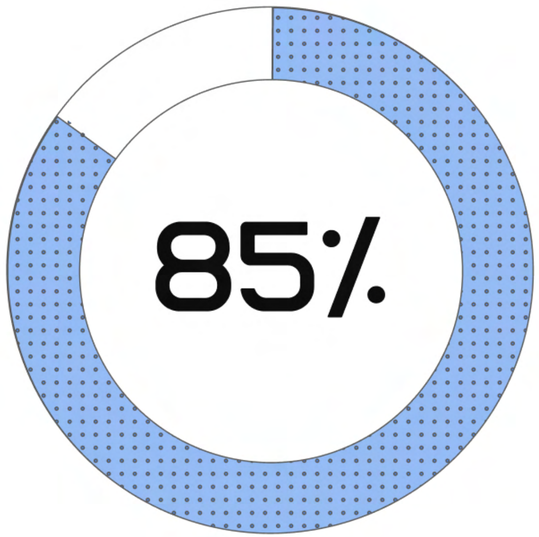
Results you can expect



Uplift in conversion



Increase in repeat purchases



Faster go-to-market

Retail & store operations leaders

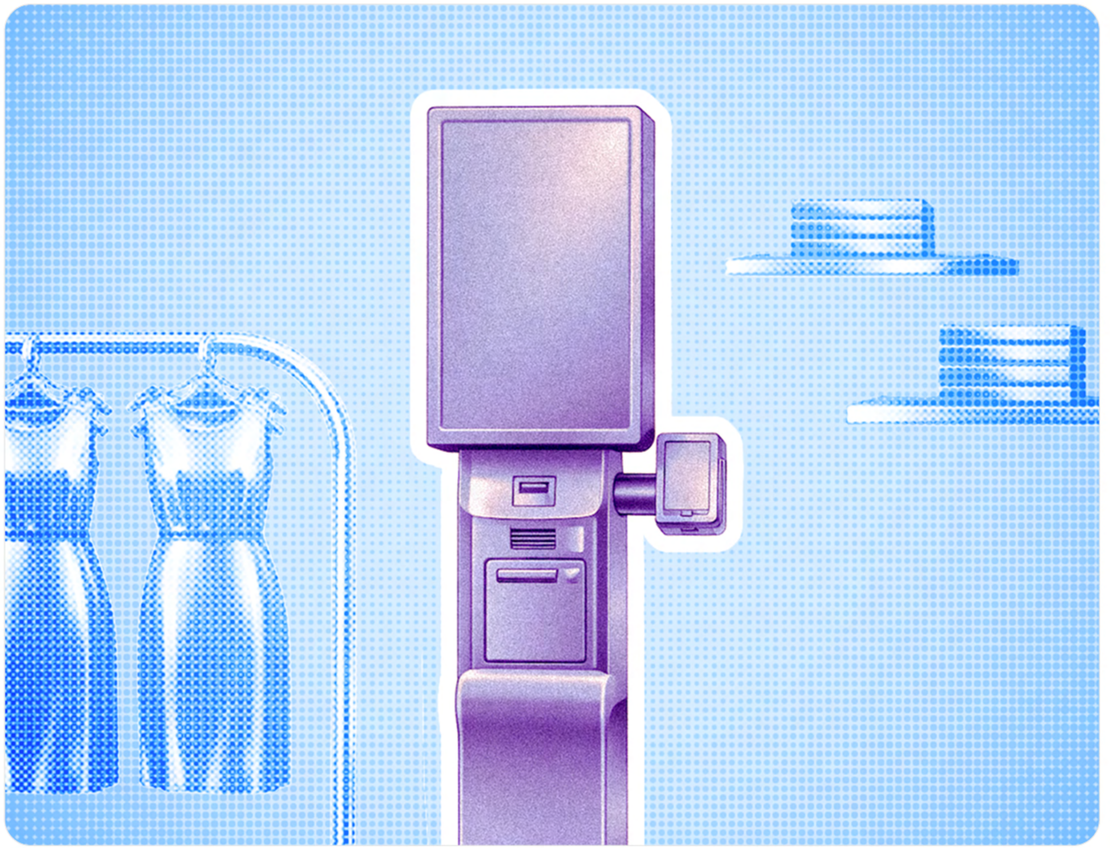
For COOs, Heads of Retail, Heads of Store Ops, CXOs

Your mandate in 2026

Make stores earn their place as **sales, fulfillment and experience hubs**

Give staff **easy-to-use digital tools** that support omnichannel journeys

Reduce friction in pickup, returns and in-store experiences



Your 2026 action agenda

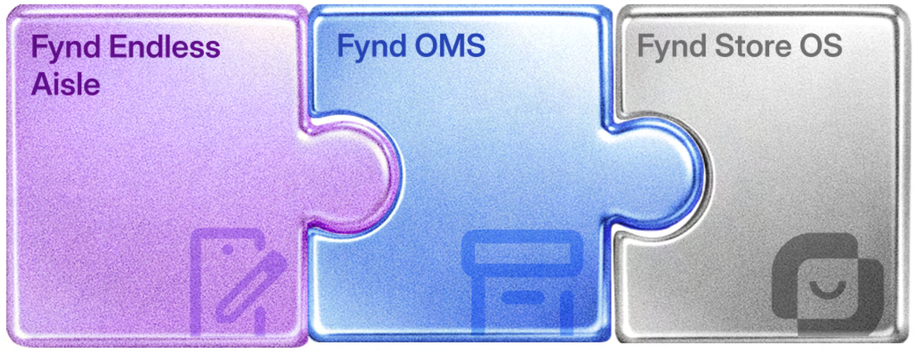
Redefine store KPIs for an omnichannel world

Don't manage stores on walk-in sales alone. Measure total business influenced: in-store sales + online orders fulfilled or assisted by that store.

Move from static reports → daily actions. Give store managers clear task feeds

Use this to reframe internal conversations: Stores as revenue + fulfillment + CX nodes, not just cost centres

Ensure centralized inventory orders, and returns across store, ecommerce, and supply chain



for unified inventory visibility, online & offline

central logic for BOPIS, ship-from-store, omni-returns and order allocation

for unified reporting & analytics

Give store teams one simple, unified tool

Replace fragmented systems with a single interface for billing, inventory lookup for all locations, endless aisle orders, clienteling and CRM, selfcheckouts / kiosks, returns, and cash management

Turn staff into trusted advisors. Give them access to customer profiles, purchases, and wishlists to build personalized looks, routines, and recommendations that make customers feel known

Reduce training time and errors, increase adoption

for assisted selling

for CRM and customer profiles

for faster checkouts

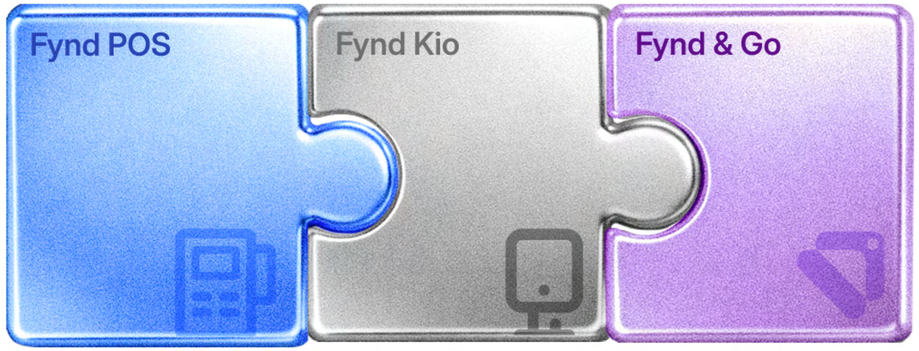
Speed up checkout to protect NPS, basket value, and staff productivity

When value shoppers dominate, time saved and friction removed are part of the loyalty & value proposition

Use modern POS + self-checkout to cut queue times, especially during weekends and events

Let low-assistance baskets move via self checkout kiosks or scan and go

Redirect freed-up staff time to assisted selling, cross-sell and clienteling, not just billing



for omnichannel checkouts & returns

self checkout terminals for busy locations

for scan-and-go on customer devices

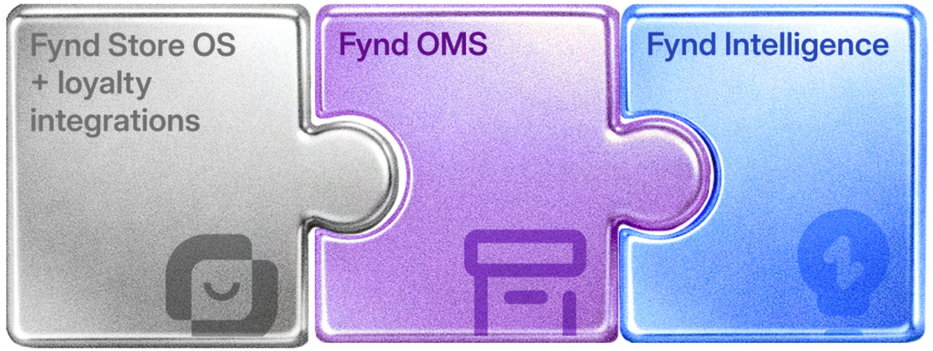
Connect store journeys to loyalty and repeat business

If value shoppers dominate, rewards and recognition must show up at the till, not hidden in an app.

Link POS and self-checkout to loyalty and rewards, so customers feel the benefit at the bill, not in a buried app tab

Use receipt, WhatsApp and email flows to bring them back with relevant, value-led offers

Treat returns, exchanges and pickups as another chance to deepen the relationship, not just a cost. Use all service moments as purchase opportuinity



for unified rewards eligibility at checkout

for running cross-channel loyalty programs

cohorts and journeys for repeat nudges

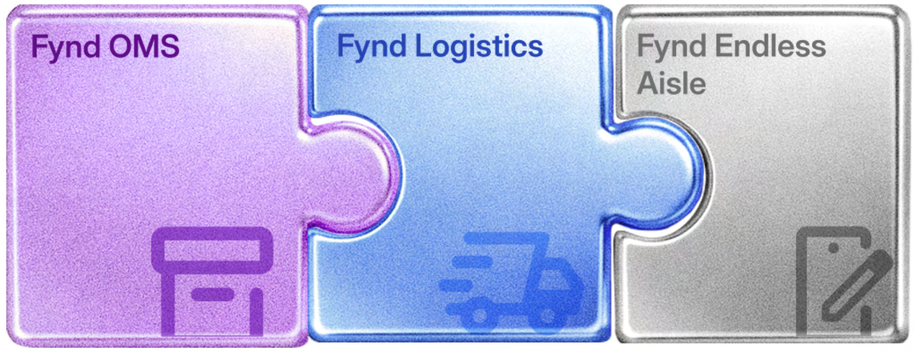
Turn stores into planned fulfilment & service nodes, not ad-hoc backup

Stores can no longer be “just” P&L islands. They’re where customers buy, pick up, return, exchange and get reassured

Route orders based on stock, proximity and SLA

Give store teams full visibility into online orders, payments and promises to handle service confidently

Make BOPIS, BORIS, ship-from-store and endless aisle standard, not special projects



to route orders across all fulfillment nodes

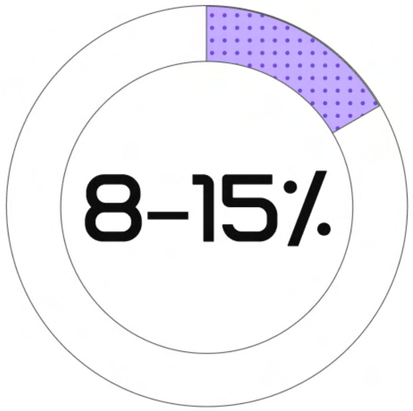
to allocate the most efficient courier

for unified orders, inventory, and returns

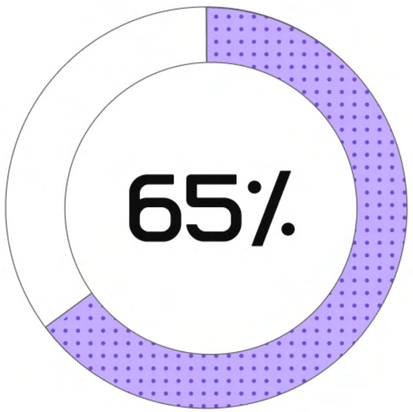
Pro tip for retail & store ops leaders

If store performance still depends on people remembering what to do, you don’t have a store strategy, you have operational risk. Make workflows decide first, staff execute second.

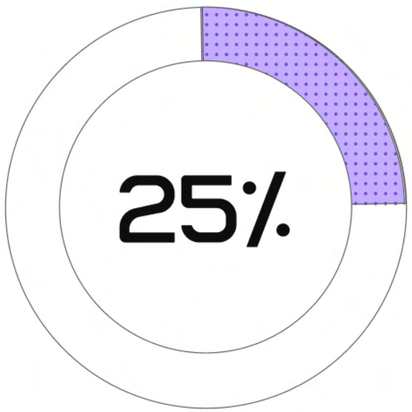
Results you can expect



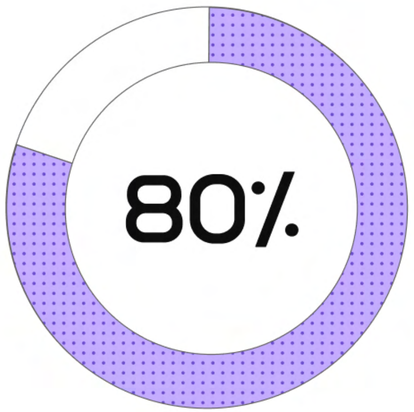
Additional store sales



Faster checkout time



Higher repeat store visits



Higher adoption of omnichannel workflows

Supply chain, fulfillment & logistics leaders

For CSCOs, Heads of Supply Chain, Logistics Heads, COOs

Your mandate in 2026

Protect margins across warehousing, transportation, and last-mile delivery

Deliver faster without increasing failure rates, returns, or logistics costs

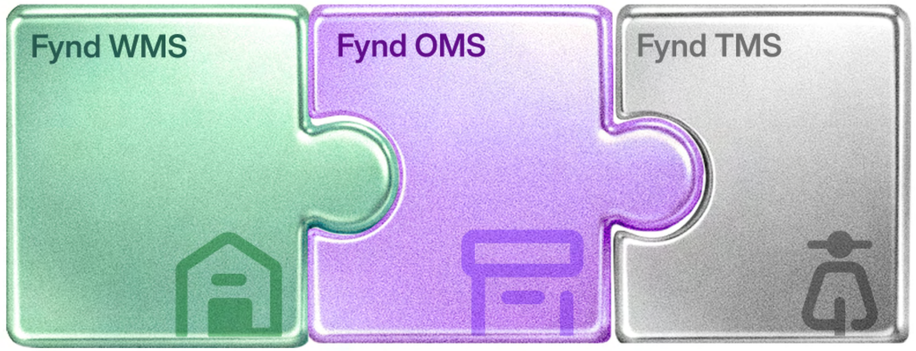
Run a supply chain that is predictable, scalable, and visible end-to-end

Your 2026 action agenda

Fix margin leakage across warehousing, transportation, and last mile

When shoppers default to lower price bands, margin is lost silently inside operations, not just at pricing

- Get visibility into cost per order across DCs, dark stores, stores, and delivery lanes
- Reduce avoidable handling, re-routing, and emergency fulfillment caused by poor inventory accuracy
- Treat NDR, RTO, and returns as economic metrics, not just service metrics



for inventory accuracy, FIFO & ageing visibility

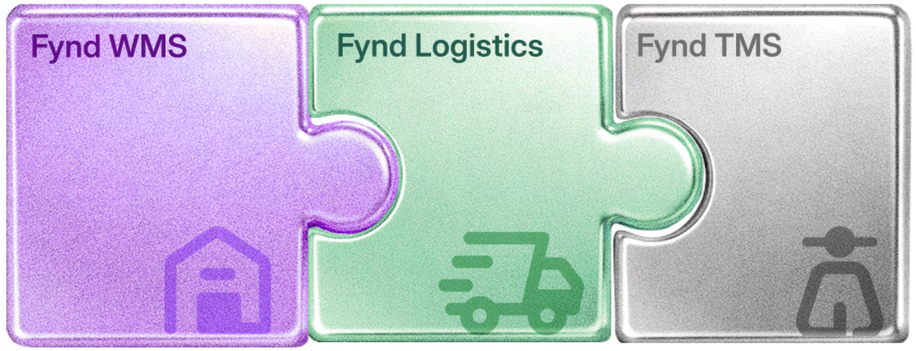
for cost-optimized fulfillment

for route & capacity optimization

Use AI to prevent failures, not just react to them

AI in supply chains should remove human bottlenecks in high-volume decisions

- Anticipate demand and replenishment shifts early
- Improve routing, address accuracy, and carrier selection before dispatch
- Resolve delivery exceptions and NDRs automatically, at scale



for demand prediction

for AI-driven NDR automation

for dynamic courier assignment & routing

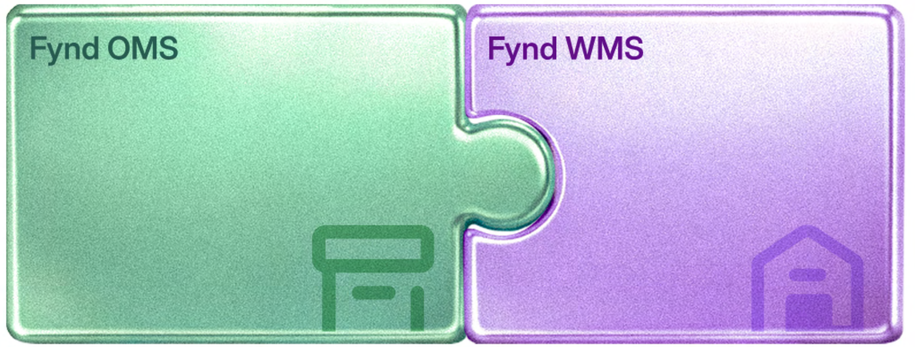
Build a unified logistics control layer

Fragmented systems make speed expensive and failures invisible

Operate with one live view of orders, inventory, and shipments across all nodes

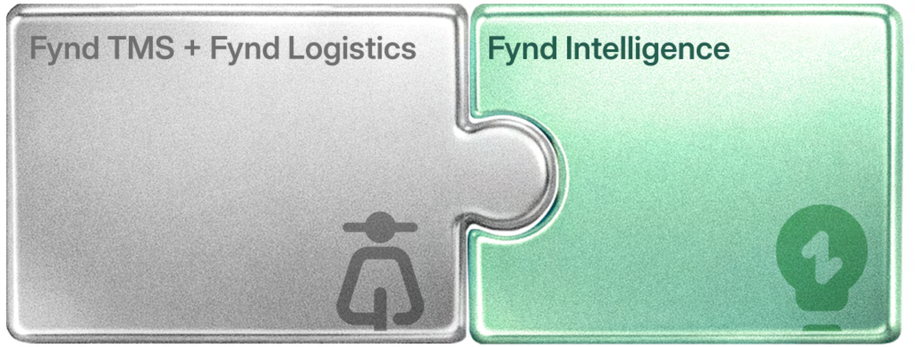
Coordinate DCs, dark stores, retail stores, and carriers through a single execution layer

Replace reactive firefighting with predictable, system-driven fulfillment decisions



for central management across channels and fulfilllment nodes

for real-time warehouse execution



for transport and last-mile execution

for AI insights on cost, SLA, inventory, and risk

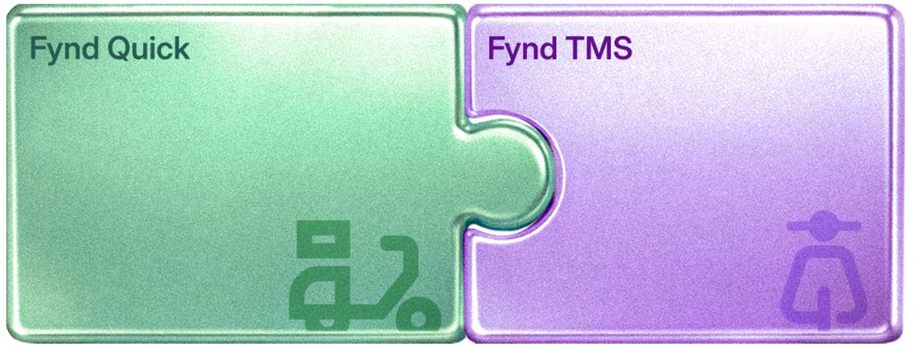
Make faster delivery a scalable, disciplined capability

Speed is expected, but reliability differentiates when margins are tight. Engineer faster delivery to improve first-attempt success, not just reduce transit time.

Support same-day, next-day, and quick commerce through planned dark-store and store-based fulfillment

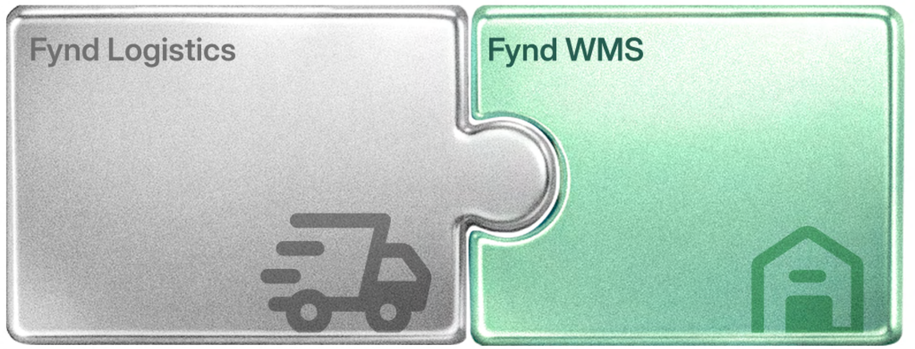
Secure additional delivery capacity during peak periods through a carrier ecosystem, not extra hiring

Ensure faster promises do not increase failure rates or cost per order



for dark store fulfillment by zone and SKU

for route & capacity planning, and zone-based serviceability



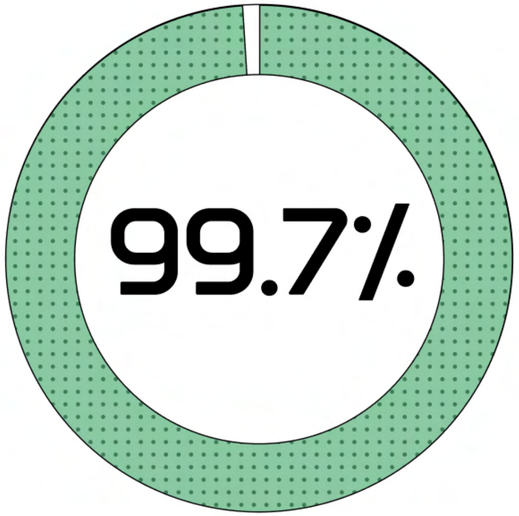
for scalable carrier access during peak volumes

for high-accuracy, high-velocity pick-pack cycles

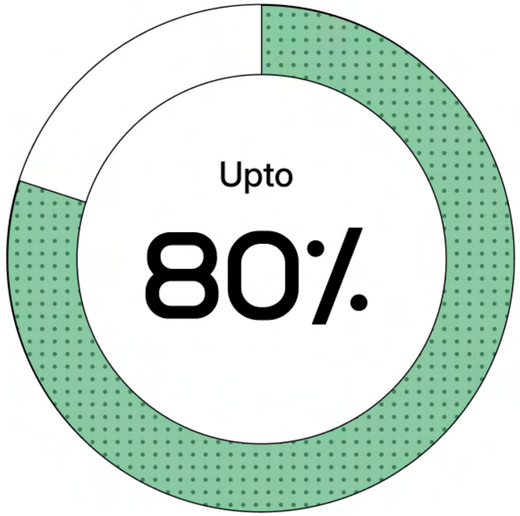
Pro tip for supply chain & fulfillment leaders

Predictability beats speed. Build systems to prevent failures, not teams to fix them. Write your SLA strategy first, then configure OMS, WMS, TMS and logistics to serve that strategy, not the other way around.

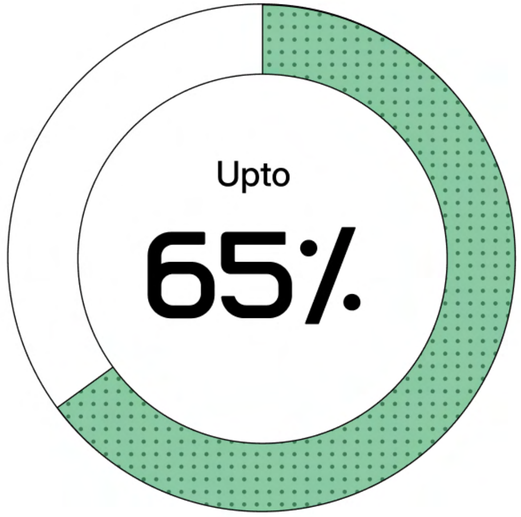
Results you can expect



Inventory accuracy



Improvement in on-time delivery

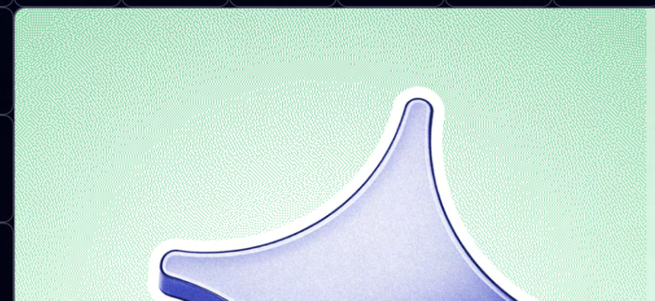


Reduction in logistics costs

Fynd

04 THE AI-NATIVE COMMERCE PLAYBOOK

How To Leverage AI Across The Commerce Journey



~~How do we use AI in commerce?~~

Which decisions should never wait for humans again?

Planning & design

Identify trends that fit your brand

Use AI to track global fashion signals and filter them through your brand, customer, price, and geography to **launch while trends are still relevant.**

Convert trends into design-ready direction

Generate AI-led moodboards and 2D/3D line sheets to align teams faster and **cut manual interpretation cycles.**

Lock production-ready designs earlier

Use high-volume AI design options and early tech packs to finalize designs **before cost and capacity are committed.**

Reduce late-stage rework

Lock manufacturing and quality constraints early, **minimizing late changes, unnecessary samples, production inefficiencies, and post-launch corrections.**

- For apparel brands

Cataloging

Replace manual catalog creation and correction

Standardize titles, attributes, metadata, and compliance fields directly from design inputs, **reducing listing errors.**

Automate enrichment and channel-readiness

Autofill missing attributes and adapt PDPs per marketplace for **high converting, complete, and consistent PDPs.**

Decouple go-to-market speed from studio capacity

Generate product imagery and videos at scale without waiting on physical shoots and **lower content cost per SKU.**

Treat catalog quality as a returns control system

Detect mismatch risks (size, missing specs, misleading imagery), flag high-risks early to **reduce *"not as expected" returns.***

- For apparel brands

Discovery & conversion

Replace page-led browsing with agent-led discovery

Use AI agents to interpret intent and exploration into relevant shortlists, comparisons, and next actions for **higher discovery**.

Use visual intelligence to reduce buying risk, not as engagement features

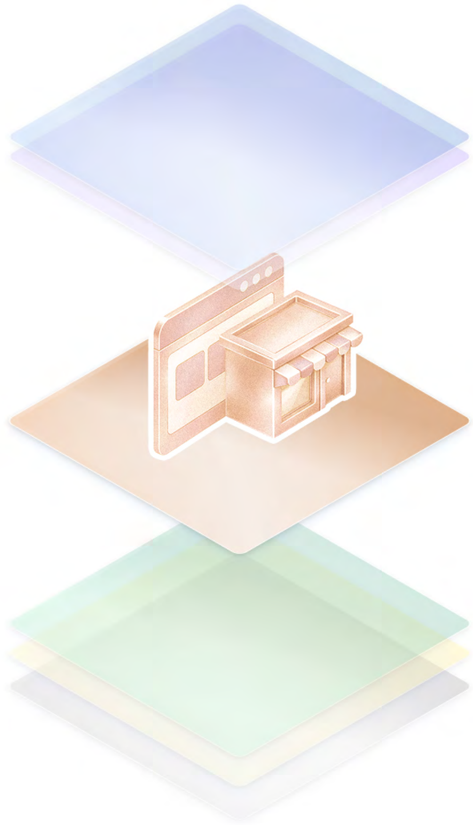
Deploy 3D and AR to validate fit and usage context before purchase and structurally **lower return rates.**

Unify discovery, conversion, and service into a single agentic flow

Let AI agents guide discovery, answer questions, add to cart, modify orders, and handle exchanges.

Keep discovery and merchandising adaptive, not rule-based

Use real-time behaviour, inventory, and demand to adjust product ranking, offers, bundles, and pricing to **avoid blanket discounting.**



Warehousing & fulfillment

Let AI decide fulfillment centers

Embed real-time AI decisioning to evaluate cost, inventory risk, SLA probability, and node capacity before routing.

Use AI-enforced inventory accuracy and ageing discipline

Move FIFO, scan compliance, and ageing visibility out of SOPs and into system execution to **maintain sell-throughs.**

Compress warehouse time-to-ship

Move wave planning and pick-paths into AI-led execution for faster dispatch and **more predictable peak performance.**

Anticipate capacity stress instead of firefighting

Use AI to detect early signals of backlog, capacity overload, or SLA risk and trigger corrective actions ahead of impact.

Delivery, NDR & last mile

Engineer delivery reliability

Use AI to assess serviceability, lane risk, and capacity before committing delivery promises improving first-attempt success.

AI-optimized routing and courier selection

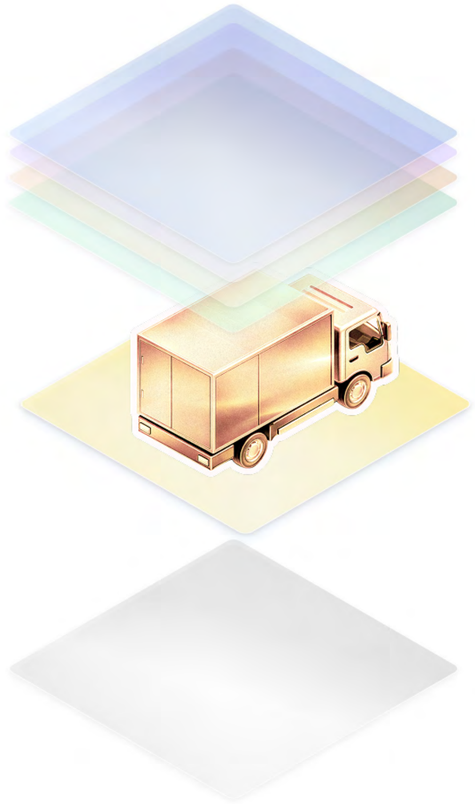
Balance cost, SLA, and real-time capacity instead of fixed courier rules and lower shipping costs and SLA breaches.

Prevent address-led failures before dispatch

Run AI-driven checks to fix or confirm risky addresses before labels are generated and shipments move out.

Treat NDR as a prevention, not a support queue

Use AI to identify delivery risk early, trigger customer communication, capture responses, and auto-schedule reattempts.



Delivery, NDR & last mile

Route returns with AI-driven recovery decisioning

Use AI to decide restock, redirect, repair, liquidate, or write-off based on condition, demand, and age to reduce capital lockup and speeds resale.

Run post-purchase resolution at scale without linear support growth

Use conversational AI to handle post-purchase queries, returns initiation, exchanges, refunds, and order changes in one continuous flow instead of tickets manual intervention, or multi-team handoffs.

Your AI-native Fynd toolkit to deliver this

Planning & design

Fynd Create

- AI trendspotting
- AI moodboards
- Fit & drape simulation
- Production ready tech packs

Cataloging

Fynd AI PIM

- AI attribute creation & enrichment
- Channel-specific schema mapping
- Marketplace compliance
- Auto error fixes

Fynd Snap

- AI images
- On-model, flat-lay, lifestyle imagery
- Short PDP videos
- Face & body swaps

Discovery & conversion

Kaily

- Intent-based recommendation
- Agent-led conversions
- Assisted checkouts

Fynd Storefronts

- No-code experimentation
- Dynamic layouts, bundles, pricing

Fynd Intelligence

- Behaviour-based product ranking
- Margin-aware decision

GlamAR

- 3D, AR, and VR solutions

Your AI-native Fynd toolkit to deliver this

Fulfillment, allocation & warehousing

Fynd OMS
- Cost-aware order routing
- Node eligibility logic
- Split / merge intelligence

Onshelf
- Store stock accuracy signals

Fynd WMS
- AI inventory accuracy enforcement
- FIFO / ageing prioritization
- High-velocity pick-pack

Fynd Intelligence
- Capacity stress prediction

Delivery, NDR & last mile

Fynd TMS
- AI route optimization
- Lane-level SLA scoring
- Capacity-aware dispatch
- Zone base serviceability

Boltic
- Exception workflow orchestration

Fynd Logistics
- AI NDR automation
- Address correction
- Carrier ecosystem auto scaling

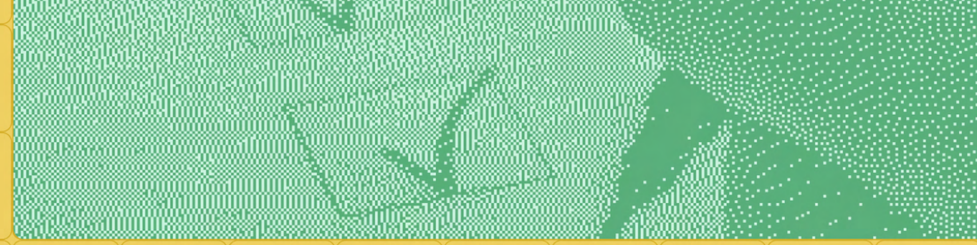
Post-purchase

Fynd OMS
- Return eligibility logic
- Reverse routing decisions

Kaily
- Conversational support
- Exchange & refund flows

Fynd WMS
- AI-prioritized QC
- Fast stock reintegration

Fynd Intelligence
- Return pattern learning



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05 THE C-SUITE CHECKLIST

20 Decisions For 2026

Read this as a roadmap, not a scorecard. If your systems can't do these by default yet, your teams are filling the gaps. Closing that gap is the real leadership mandate for 2026

Your readiness check for 2026

AI participates in core commerce decisions, not just reporting
(assortment, routing, pricing exposure, returns handling)

The system can decide and act, not only recommend
(reroute orders, suppress risky promises, block bad listings)

Product, order, inventory, and delivery data operate as one live system, not reconciled views

Speed is engineered through AI-led routing and zone intelligence

Discovery and conversion are intent-led, not page-led

- Visual confidence (3D / AR / guided buying) is treated as a risk-reduction layer, not an engagement feature
- Fulfillment decisions optimize speed + reliability together
- Inventory accuracy and ageing are system-enforced, not process-audited
- Delivery failures are predicted and prevented, not chased after escalation
- NDR, returns, and recovery operate as automated flows, not support workloads
- Returned inventory is treated as recoverable value, not dead stock by default

Post-purchase moments are resolved in one flow, not split across tools and teams

Learning loops are closed

(returns, delivery failures, and drop-offs feed upstream decisions)

Performance improves without linear headcount growth

(the system absorbs complexity)

If volume doubles and margins tighten, the system adapts first, not people

Fynd

06 REAL VOICES REAL ANSWERS

Voices Of Top Leaders

Biggest learnings from 2025

knya

”Distribution strength compounds faster than product excellence alone.”

We always believed product quality would win over time, and it does, but 2025 reinforced that how and where you show up matters just as much. Brands that cracked omnichannel execution, tight supply chains, and rapid feedback loops outpaced those that were only product-led.

It changed how we run the business by making us far more execution-obsessed: tighter inventory turns, faster launch-to-feedback cycles, and treating every channel (D2C, marketplaces, offline) as one integrated growth engine rather than silos.

Abhijeet Kaji
Co-Founder, Knya Med

The[Pant]Pro·ject

Especially for the offline business, curating products with better customer needs vs latest trend match on ground led to better throughput at stores and helped generate the needed customer delight and business growth. Customer are willing to explore and experiment so the opportunity to experience the product and see the visual appeal helped make decisions to move away from fashion constants in the wardrobe.

Sharath Raju
VP Retail

ALMANA LOGISTICS
المانع للخدمات اللوجستية

2025 reinforced a simple truth. Resilience doesn't come from reacting faster, it comes from designing supply chains that absorb shock without drama. Simplicity, visibility, and disciplined execution mattered more than complexity.

Shailen Shukla
General Manager, Almana Logistics (Sarco Oman group)

My biggest learning in 2025 was the importance of building resilient and adaptable supply chains, especially in a category increasingly shaped by health awareness and regulation. As excise taxes and sugar-related policies continue to evolve in the region, having strong, direct relationships with brand partners and clear operational visibility became essential. Agility, rather than pure efficiency, proved critical to responding quickly to regulatory change while continuing to serve customers consistently.

Erika Blazeviciute Doyle
Founder & CEO, Drink Dry

DrinkDry
CELEBRATE EVERY DAY

CANTABIL ITALY
International Clothing

"2025 was the year Q-commerce moved beyond groceries into lifestyle essentials."

Urban consumers now expect instant gratification for fashion staples like basic tees, shirts, and accessories. Our strategic Q-commerce partnerships enabled our curated collections to be delivered to customers within minutes. This transformed e-commerce from a slow delivery channel into a high-frequency, hyperlocal sales engine that now accounts for roughly 6% of our total revenue.

Another significant consumer insight was that tier 2 and tier 3 cities are no longer just looking for 'cheap' clothing, they are seeking a high-street experience at an accessible price. Consumers in smaller towns are migrating toward organized retail for trust and quality.

Varun Kashyap
Ecom Manager, Ecom Manager, Cantabil

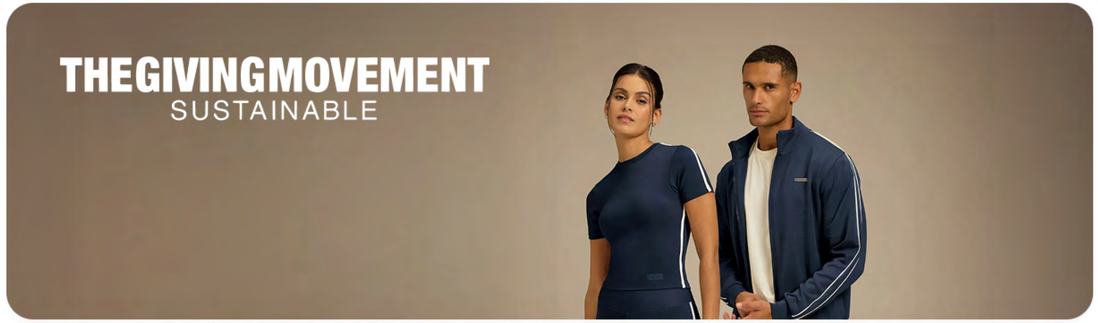
WILD STONE

”Execution matters far more than strategy and planning”

Many times, we spend months working towards what looks like a perfect strategy on paper. But when it finally hits the ground, reality behaves very differently. Markets react differently, teams interpret things their own way and consumers don’t always respond as expected.

What this taught me is that strategy is important only to give direction and take the first step. The remaining 50 percent of the strategy actually gets built during execution through learning on the go, fixing mistakes and adapting quickly. Planning can set intent, but execution is what truly completes the strategy.

Mohit Kiradoo
Strategy & Ops, Strategy & Ops, McNROE (Wildstone)



The industry-wide pivot to profitability proved far more challenging than growth optimization ever was. At TGM, we transformed from discount-driven operations to full-price leadership - gross margins up 10 points, full-price sales up 25 points, hitting audacious EBITDA targets through disciplined operational excellence. This came as performance marketing costs surged 45% YoY and privacy regulations made attribution murky. The lesson? Premium positioning cannot be shortcut - operational excellence must lead brand ambition. Prioritizing quality over volume, simplifying ranges, and maintaining pricing discipline delivered sustainable results where promotional tactics failed. In MENA, especially, authentic homegrown value outlasts growth tactics.

Marc Jeffery
COO/CTO, The Giving Movement

What's next in 2026

knya

"Doubling down on deep omnichannel commerce powered by first-party data."

This means using offline stores not just as sales points but as acquisition, retention, and trust-building engines, fully connected to online behavior, CRM, and personalization.

The next wave of commerce is not about new platforms; it's about better orchestration. Brands that can unify customer data across touchpoints and deliver consistent pricing, availability, and experience will win disproportionately.

Abhijeet Kaji
Co-Founder

The[Pant]Pro·ject

Utilizing AI visualization, experiential shopping with increased digital touchpoints in our offline stores is something we plan to go heavier on, because based on our pilot runs made, customers really appreciated this immersion of how my shopping journey can be enhanced by mapping trend vs my choice vs show me what's new opportunity. Category level personalization is something we would specifically focus on to enhance customer journey better in the coming year.

Sharath Raju
VP Retail

ALMANA LOGISTICS
المانع للخدمات اللوجستية

In 2026, the focus is on turning data into decisions. Not more dashboards, but smarter use of AI and planning tools to improve forecast accuracy, inventory discipline, and execution at the last mile.

Shailen Shukla
General Manager

In 2026, I'm most excited about further strengthening data-driven demand planning and automation across our supply chain. As regulation and excise tax structures increasingly influence product mix, pricing, and consumer behaviour, real-time data allows us to plan more intelligently and scale responsibly. Technology that connects regulation-aware planning with inventory and commercial decision-making will be a key competitive advantage for modern retailers.

Erika Blazeviciute Doyle
Founder & CEO, Drink Dry

DrinkDry
CELEBRATE EVERY DAY

CANTABIL
International Clothing

We are moving from a phase of 'rapid physical expansion' into a phase of 'intelligent omnichannel maturity'

The most critical shift for us is implementing unified commerce via ERP & POS overhaul. having a single source of truth for inventory across all 650+ stores and digital warehouses will enable us to ship from store, significantly reducing e-commerce delivery times and preventing stockouts. Our urban stores will act as hyperlocal fulfillment centers.

Alongside we we also aim to transitioning our small-format stores to larger-format outlets serving a larger experience centers, investing in data-driven merchandising, and shifting our digital focus from 'inventory clearance' to 'brand-led growth'.

Varun Kashyap
Ecom Manager

WILD STONE

”Our focus is on deeper integration of offline retail with real time data and feedback loops.”

Physical retail is no longer just a sales channel. It is the biggest source of consumer insight if the systems are built right. POS data, staff inputs, repeat behaviour and drop offs need to flow back into decisions on inventory, training and even product development.

We want stores to act less like endpoints and more like listening posts. The brands that win will be the ones that learn the fastest from the shop floor and act on it without delay.

Mohit Kiradoo
Strategy & Ops

Backend AI efficiency paired with AI-powered consumer discovery will define winners over the next five years. In 2026, we're scaling AI across operations - from demand forecasting 75% more accurate than traditional methods to real-time inventory intelligence and supply chain optimization. With one in five shoppers already using third-party AI shopping assistants, we're optimising for AI discovery whilst evolving our community-led experiences. The battleground is clear: backend efficiency must meet frontend AI convenience - because whilst consumers expect hyper-efficient AI tools, they still demand human connection and elevated conventional shopping experiences. Brands anchored in authentic purpose win both battles.

Marc Jeffery
COO/CTO

Fynd

Conclusion

THE END OF MANUAL COMMERCE

There will be two types of companies in the future: those that are great at AI, and those that used to be in business

Mark Cuban

The next phase of commerce will not be won by teams that work harder, add more tools, or react faster.

It will be won by systems that:

Autonomous commerce is not about removing humans from the equation.

It is about freeing leaders and teams from manual intervention loops, so judgment is applied where it matters , and systems handle the rest.

In 2026, the defining question for every CXO is no longer:

"Do we use AI?"

It is:

Which decisions can our system already take without us and which still depend on heroics?

Wishing you a more decisive and resilient 2026!!!

That's a wrap!

About Fynd

Fynd is an AI-native platform focusing on retail solutions, empowering 2,300+ brands that enrich our expertise in the retail industry. With our annual publications and reports on the retail landscape, we aim to aid their growth and offer insights to act strategically.

Scan the QR to schedule a call with our team

www.fynd.com